



Music of the World

OPTIMA ACADEMY ONLINE · FAMILY COURSE OVERVIEW · GRADES 9–12 · FULL YEAR · 1 CREDIT

~4¼ hrs per week · 50 min/day, M–F

About this overview. This document is an example of how the course might be taught. More musical works are approved for study than appear here, so scholars may see some variation in songs, topics, and activities from course to course, and between the live school and On-Demand. Each teacher also leans into their own strengths and passions; the structure, expectations, and time commitment below are representative of the course as designed.

Music of the World introduces scholars to the musical traditions of the 20th and 21st centuries across American and global cultures. Scholars listen to and analyze jazz, world drumming, mariachi, soul, gamelan, Bollywood, and digital music — understanding how music functions within different cultures to express identity, tell stories, celebrate, mourn, and create community. Through careful listening and study of these diverse traditions, scholars develop appreciation for how cultures express themselves through music and recognize shared human experiences across musical forms. VR and AI resources support exploring traditions in their cultural context. The deepest skill the course builds is listening — hearing what music expresses and why it matters to the communities that create it.

THE YEAR AT A GLANCE

1 Listening Deeply (all year)

Strategies for unfamiliar works, comparing performances of the same piece, and evaluating recorded and live performances with real music vocabulary.

3 Instruments and Structures (all year)

Classifying instruments of the world by common traits, and analyzing how organization and expressive elements shape a work.

5 Making and Arranging (woven through)

Improvising over harmonic progressions, arranging a musical work, and performance and presentation projects.

2 Traditions of the World (all year)

Jazz, world drumming, mariachi, soul, gamelan, Bollywood, and digital music — each studied in its cultural home.

4 Music, Technology, and Industry (all year)

How traditional and contemporary technologies shaped music; the arts economy; copyright and responsible use of recorded music.

6 Music in Context (woven through)

How world cultures have shaped Western music, music's social impact across history — and live performances may extend the learning.

A TYPICAL WEEK

- Focused listening sessions most days, with analysis and discussion in accurate music vocabulary.
- A tradition or genre focus that moves around the world across the year.
- Creative and research tasks: improvisations, arrangements, and reports on music in culture.
- VR explorations that place musical traditions in their cultural context.

On-Demand (asynchronous). Scholars move through the course at their own pace, with due dates to keep the year on track. An Optima teacher is available throughout for support, feedback, and grading.

TIME COMMITMENT

250 minutes / week

≈ 50 minutes a day, Monday–Friday

- Listening, analysis, and discussion fill most of the scheduled time.
- Projects and performances may run longer; attending a live performance may be part of the course.

WHAT SCHOLARS NEED

- A computer with reliable internet and access to Canvas.
- Good headphones — this is a listening course.
- A notebook for music vocabulary and listening notes.

Live school. Live-school scholars take this same course on Optima's VR campus with a teacher and classmates, meeting daily on the school's schedule.